Graphic Design

What is Graphic Design?

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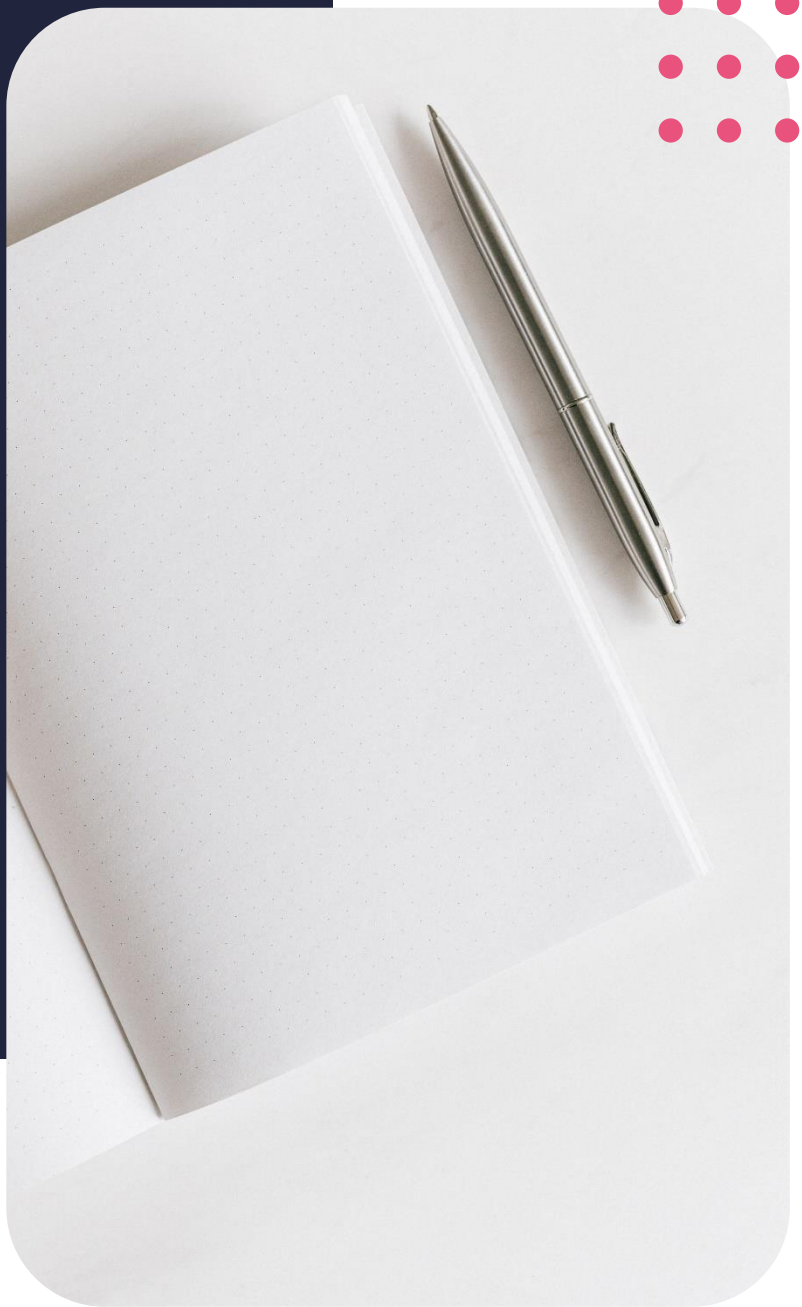
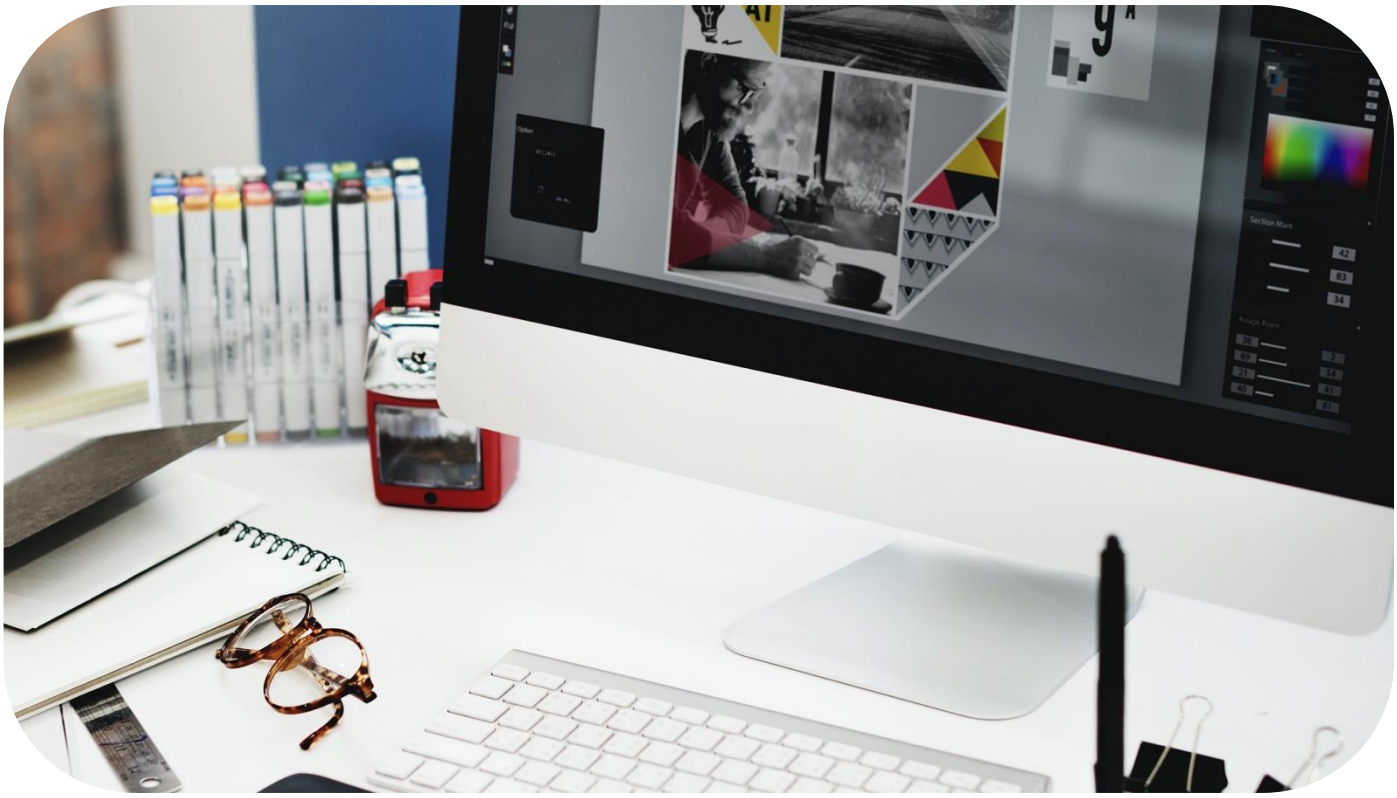


What is graphic design?

Graphic design is a form of visual communication. This means that a graphic designer uses visuals consisting of illustrations, text and photographs to communicate to a target audience visually.

Graphic design needs to communicate effectively. This means that if the design you created using all these elements (photography, illustrations and text) does not communicate effectively, irrespective of how interesting or aesthetically pleasing it may seem, your task as a designer is not done.

Graphic design is there to make our everyday lives more convenient and hassle free without us realising it, thus we like to say that good design is transparent or invisible since we do not ever realise it. Graphic designers are creative problem solvers.



The role of graphic design

Graphic design is so much more than simply being artistic. As mentioned, good design is transparent or invisible, it is there to make our everyday lives more convenient and hassle free without us realising it. Consider the use of a very simple traffic icon. Its purpose is to direct you as quickly as possible. These icons are even universal, meaning that almost anyone, irrespective of their language or cultural background, will be able to understand these icons.

Imagine how the world would function without the use of visual communication?
Having the ability to understand visual communication helps us navigate through life on a daily basis.

The basic building blocks of design are referred to as the design elements. The elements of design consist of space, line, shape, size, texture, value and colour – all and any designs you have ever witnessed consist out of a combination of these elements.

Space: Space has the power to enhance certain elements.

Line: Line can be referred to as the primal element since all other elements consist out of some sort of line.

Shape: Shape is a closed form of line and can also be referred to as form.

Size: Size helps to create emphasis and you have a general sense of the most important factors in a composition.

Texture: Texture aids in bringing depth to your artwork. It can either be physical or implied.

Value: Value refers to the lightness or darkness of an element. These are the tones between light and dark and value helps to emphasis certain aspects of your design.

Colour: Colour is another great tool to help create emphasis but also to determine mood. Colour is probably one of the most important elements and understanding colour psychology, will aid you a lot when creating designs.

The elements of design might seem quite simple but the process of applying them is what makes a professional designer stand out from an amateur.

Why is history so important?

One of the most important reasons is the fact that history helps us in making connections. It allows you in understanding your past, which in return connects to your future. It creates awareness and understanding and helps you to gain insight into different cultures that you might not be familiar with.

One such example is the invention of the book, referring specifically to the shape of a book. Before the advent of books, which were referred to as codices (plural for codex) back in the Middle ages, people used to make use of scrolls and stone or clay tablets. Both these options were quite impractical and difficult to carry around and so, the codex was born.

Another interesting history fact is the invention of the printing press in 1450 by Johannes Gutenberg from Germany. Why is this invention so important? Well, if it weren't for Johannes Gutenberg, we would all still probably be illiterate today (assuming nobody else came up with a similar invention).

The printing press had such an impact that before its invention, society had only an upper and lower class. After the invention of the printing press, it allowed thousands of people the opportunity to become literate thus creating a middle class in Europe that spread across the world.

History timeline of graphic design

During the Prehistoric times, around 20000-15000BC it is believed that the Lascaux paintings in France were created. There are over 600 paintings covering the ceiling and walls of these caves. What these paintings have in common with graphic design is the fact that we believe this might be the apex of visual communication where humans started to communicate visually in order to give them some form of power over these creatures since they mostly lived as hunter-gatherers. It is also a means to preserve a time in history as well as memories.

In about 3200BC the Sumerians settled in Mesopotamia (which is now known as Iraq) from their nomad and restless wanderings. The fact that the Sumerians settled, probably made them aware of other skills and tools. One such skill is writing, which is a form of visual communication. The first form of writing was known as Cuneiform and shortly after the invention of writing Hieroglyphs was invented by the Egyptians.

Skip over 4000 years and some major inventions in-between as well, we find ourselves in the middle ages in 1450 where Johannes Gutenberg, a goldsmith, invented the printing press which was inspired by combining a woodblock printing created by the Chinese in 220AD, the winepress, and moveable type. This invention of the printing press helped the spread of information quickly and accurately and as mentioned, help civilisation to become literate.

Skip another 500 years and we find ourselves at the Bauhaus movement. What makes The Bauhaus art school situated in Germany so significant is the fact that it operated from 1919 until just before the 2nd world war - for only a really short period of 14 years. However, this art school had an enormous impact on modern design. Its influence reached all forms of design and art from architecture to graphic design. Bauhaus is the epitome of "form follows function" and its founder Walter Gropius, German architect believed that art and design could be brought to anyone by making everyday objects more interesting and functional. It's influence can still be seen today as it created the gateway for modern design.

On 24 January 1984, Steve Jobs introduced the very first Apple Macintosh computer. Why is this so significant? Well, the Apple MacIntosh was the 1st personal computer to popularise the use of a mouse as well as a graphical user interface. We all know what a computer mouse is and can almost not imagine using a computer without a mouse but to put things into more perspective: a graphical user interface is a way of interacting visually with a computer making use of icons, menus and folders and simply clicking and moving items around with your mouse – basically, exactly how we make use of computers today.

In 1987, Illustrator was commercialised and was initially an in-house font development software. Today, we use Adobe Illustrator for the creation of logos, illustrations and for typesetting in the form of vector images.

Brothers Thomas and John Knoll created Adobe Photoshop in 1987 and Adobe purchased the licence for Photoshop in 1988. In 1990, Photoshop was released for Macintosh exclusively but in 1993 it got released for Microsoft Windows as well. Photoshop is a photo-manipulation program allowing its user to create digital art in raster format. We will start to make use of Photoshop later in the course.

Quark, the opposition to Adobe at the time released a very powerful feature rich QuarkXPress, which is a layout and design software. Quark Xpress dominated at the time and this motivated Adobe to create InDesign.

InDesign was released in 1999 and was the first native Mac OS-X DTP software. Adobe InDesign is the software that combines all your Photoshop and Illustrator created artwork into one document and in recent years have great ability in creating interactive pdf documents. Of these 3 programs, InDesign is probably my favourite.

Please note that I have not mentioned all of the historical facts and that this was merely the tip of the iceberg. You can refer to the bonus lesson and notes for more historical facts and details.

What do you need in order to become a graphic designer?

As you continue with this course and get practical experience, you will get to understand these programs better. In short, Adobe Illustrator is a vector-based program, and like the name implies, is used to create illustrations. Examples are logos, corporate identities, posters and basically anything you can digitally draw on the computer. The amazing thing about vector illustrations is that they never lose quality and are very small in file size.

Photoshop on the other hand is a photo-manipulation program used not only by graphic designers but also photographers, animators, fine artists, and other creative industry careers. You will make use of photoshop to enhance or manipulate photographs and it also has the ability to create posters and other artwork. The difference in Photoshop is that it delivers content in raster format and not vector format. Raster format means that the image consists out of pixels.

InDesign, which you know is my favourite is a layout-based program and mostly used for the creation of books, magazines and e-publications. It has the ability to combine all your Illustrator and Photoshop artwork into one document. Illustrator has great ability in creating interactivity into e-publication and interactive pdf documents, making these documents really user-friendly for your end-user to manage.

Graphic design careers

Graphic design even correlates with other careers and sometimes it can be the stepping stone into a different type of design career. For now, however, we will have a look at the various graphic design careers, and also the skills needed to become these designers.

I have stumbled across an interesting article in which Emily Goorewich (2019) explains these types of roles. You can view the link in the course content provided.

The types of design careers that we will look into are:

- Advertising designer
- Environmental designer
- Publication designer
- Motion designer
- Corporate designer
- Web designer
- Packaging designer

1. **Advertising designer**
   An Advertising designer is probably the most well known and common form of design career as it entails print media ranging from brochures to magazines as well as digital design and social media design.

   The skills needed for this type of career would be the use of Adobe Illustrator, Photoshop and InDesign. You will also need to make use of bulk email management software like MailChimp or Email on Acid.

   Examples of what you will be able to do as an advertising designer are:

   - Magazines and Newspapers
   - Brochure design
   - Email newsletters
   - Social media graphics
   - Infographics

2. **Environmental designer**
   Environmental designers would consider architecture and the environment to make spaces and places more attractive and efficient for people to move around in. It entails aspect and knowledge of architecture, interior design, industrial design and landscaping.

   The skills needed for this type of career would be the use of Adobe Illustrator and Photoshop. These designers might also use a 3D CAD software like AutoCAD or Maya to help their clients visualise the end result before actually constructing it. Alternatively, they can simply use a photograph of the existing space and use Photoshop to add the artwork.

   Examples include:

   - Exhibition and Event spaces
   - Mural artwork
   - Signage (which nowadays can also be digital)
   - Office branding
   - Stadium and concert branding

3. **Publication designer**

   Some of these design careers tend to overlap when it comes to skill. Like an advertising designer, publication designers focus on publications like magazines and newspapers. More recently, publication designers have focused on a more digital approach including e publications and digital magazines.

   The skills needed for this type of career would be the use of Adobe Illustrator, Photoshop and InDesign.

   Examples include:

   - Books
   - E books or e publications
   - Magazines
   - Newspapers
   - Catalogues
   - Menus

4. **Motion designer**

   Motion design has gained a lot of popularity during the last decade due to technological advancements. A motion designer takes design elements and creates the illusion of movement with these elements. A very popular program to create these movements are Adobe AfterEffects. You however need to understand and learn the basics of design first before learning this program.

   The skills needed for this type of career would be the use of Adobe Illustrator, Photoshop, as well as more animated and motion based software like AfterEffects and Maya.

   This is a great way to tell a story and is being used in TV adverts, movie intros, text animation, apps and video games to mention only a few.

5. **Corporate designer**

   A company's brand needs to communicate effectively and quickly. A corporate designer's role is to aid the company in creating a successful brand that communicates successfully to its target audience. You will need to have a great understanding of the design elements and principles (which we will discuss later in this course).

   The skills needed for this type of career would be the use of Adobe Illustrator, Photoshop and InDesign but mostly Adobe Illustrator as it allows you to create illustrations including logos and corporate identities.

   Examples include

   - Logo design
   - Business card design
   - Letterhead design
   - Stationery

6. **Web designer**

   A web designer not only needs to be able to create an effective website but will also need to understand how to make this website appealing. Coding lies at the backend of being a web designer.

   The skills needed for this type of career would obviously need to be able to understand web coding but on top of that, Web designers will also make use of Adobe Illustrator, Photoshop along with web designing software like Adobe Dreamweaver or even web-based applications like Wordpress.

   Examples are the various websites you visit when browsing the internet.

7. **Packaging designer**
   The last type of designer we are discussing is a packaging designer. Packaging designers not only need to look at the aesthetics of packaging but will also need to understand which material is best to use of the given package. Walking through a grocery store, you will realise that almost every item is in some sort of package. Most of the times, it is the packaging that convinces us to buy a certain product over its rival, hence, packaging design's role is to convince its audience without them even realising.

   The skills needed for this type of career would be the use of Adobe Illustrator, Photoshop and perhaps also some InDesign.

Graphic design tips

You can make use of these tips using almost any program, from Microsoft Word and PowerPoint to the more powerful Adobe package.

You will be amazed as to how far these simple tips will aid you in creating effective design.

1. **Limit your typefaces**
   The first tip I would like to share is to limit your typefaces to only two!
   If you use too many typefaces, it will distract from your original message and your audience will focus more on the typeface used than the actual message. With this said, it is also a good idea to combine two contrasting typefaces. One interesting display typeface for headings and a transparent typeface for your body copy.

2. **Don't be scared of white space**
   White space or negative space, is an element that should be utilised and not filled. Don't be scared of large open spaces, instead have your design elements fit in nicely with your white space. White space helps to create emphasis and a lack of white space will actually create chaos and visual disturbance.

3. **Don't warp (distort) your images**
   There is no excuse to warp or distort a picture - don't warp your photos under any circumstances! Nothing says amateur as much as a distorted or warped image.

There is a simple way to avoid this and this technique works in almost all programs – if you simply hold down the SHIFT key and drag one of the corners of your image, you should retain its proportions. The first key you should press when resizing is shift and the last key to release is shift. Releasing it too early will result in image distortion.

4. **Avoid pixilation at all times**
   Pixilation is the process of forcing a too small image or very low quality image onto your design. Even if you think the image works perfectly, if it pixelates, don't use it.

   Instead, rather get a higher quality image. There are a couple of websites where you can download good quality images for free, so instead, make use of them. Please just read the fine print as you will most of the times need to credit these images. You got it for free after all, so the least you can do is give credit where it's due. Pixabay and Freepik are very popular stock websites where there are some great content you can download for free.

5. **Contrast is key**
   Be careful of little contrast, especially when it comes to text. The most important function for text is to be legible so contrast by using either size and colour or even both is key. Having said all of this, please be careful of using two vibrant colours on top of each other as well as this can exhaust your viewer.

   As with the second example, reading the content is a lot easier. Don't force poor design onto your viewer.

To recap: we looked at what graphic design is and how it affects our current lives. We then moved over to a brief introduction to the Elements of design and looked at how to practically apply these elements. We managed to cram 17 000 years' worth of history into a couple of minutes and also focused on the various types of designers the industry currently make use of. I added bonus insight at the end in the form of five tips for effective design which can be applied using any program you currently have access to.

Congratulations on completing your very first lesson!

You can send any feedback or suggestions to support@shawacademy.com

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